WINE COUNTRY CALENDAR

A SEASONAL GUIDE TO THINGS TO SEE AND DO

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Napa Lighted Art Festival

January/February

Napa Valley tends to be tranquil at the beginning of the year, making it an ideal time to visit without crowds. While January and February are some of the coldest and wettest months, the vineyards and landscape are verdant, with the region's adored canary-yellow mustard flowers popping up amid the vine rows.

It's also an excellent time to study *terroir*. A simple ripple in a vineyard can reveal where the water is retained versus better-drained soils. It's also fascinating to see the vines before and after their pruning haircuts. Before, they appear wild and tell the story of the previous growing season. Afterward, they are tidy and uniform, ready for the next growing season.

Damp weather outside is a good reason to do cozy things inside. January is **Napa Valley Restaurant Month**, with many venues offering special pricing and prix fixe menus. Some restaurants might tighten up service times with off-season days and hours, but overall it will be easier to get reservations. The **Napa Valley Truffle Festival** offers another opportunity to indulge.

Indoor activities include the **Napa Asian American Film Festival** and **Yountville International Short Film Festival**. An outdoor option that's popular with the locals is the **Napa Lighted Art Festival**–a walkable tour of downtown Napa with dramatic light sculptures. You can also hop aboard the **Napa Valley Wine Train** as a relaxed way to explore the valley.

Downtown Napa coffee shops are warming and welcoming stops, too: **Naysayer**, **Ohm**, **Moulin**, and **Ritual** are among the best. There's also **Ohm's Roastery and Coffee Lab** in the Rail Arts District of downtown Napa, where you can get a private lesson on brewing methods, latte art or coffee cupping.

And if you need an excuse to eat more chocolate, regional chocolatiers will be happy to help you and your Valentine. **Anette's**, a local favorite, serves the best hot chocolate in town. **Le Belge** creates chocolates specifically to pair with wines; their Cabernet Sauvignon offerings include a dark chocolate/lavender/black currant and a dark chocolate/espresso. **Kollar** and **Earth & Sky** craft dramatic and beautiful bonbons, petite works of art that taste even better than they look. **Woodhouse** in St. Helena is known for its version of s'mores, a homemade marshmallow dipped in either milk or dark chocolate and sandwiched between house-made graham crackers.

March/April

The first half of spring in Napa Valley brings the first signs of grapevine activity. Dormant vines awaken and have their budbreak, when the first leaves swell and burst open. Rains taper off and the weather steadily improves. Skies tend to be filled with dramatic changes in weather; dark clouds, bouts of intense sunshine and rainbows are common.

This time of year is ideal for getting in some fresh air activities before it gets too warm. There's the **Napa Valley Marathon** (along with a half marathon and 5k) if you need a challenge. **Bicycle rentals** are plentiful, and **Vine Trail Napa Valley** from downtown Napa to Yountville is a particularly beautiful stretch of paved paths. The **Old Faithful Geyser of California** just north of Calistoga goes off every 45 minutes or so and is a relaxing spot for a picnic with BYOB wine. **Skyline Ridge Park**, **Robert Louis Stevenson State Park** and **Bothe State Park** offer hiking. Adjacent to Bothe is the **Bale Grist Mill State Park**, where a fully restored 19th century water mill recalls a fascinating bit of history. The **Rector Reservoir Wildlife Area** trail is a little-known hiking trail in the middle of the valley.

There are two reservoirs east of the valley: **Lake Berryessa** and **Lake Hennessey**. Berryessa is better for boating and fishing for bass and trout, while Hennessey is smaller and quieter, with mostly bank-fishing for bass and catfish.

Napa Marathon

May/June

As summer nears, the grapevines have flowered and through self-pollination are then fertilized, revealing small, green berries. The transformation, known as "fruit set," gives the first indication of the crop to come.

Warmer weather and clear skies also means the music scene kicks into full gear around the valley. The largest festival is **BottleRock**, with multiple stages featuring a variety of live music, plus cooking demonstrations and local food and wine purveyors. Look to the **Napa Valley Jazz Getaway** and concert series at Meritage Resort and the **Oxbow RiverStage** for additional live music.

Along with the seasonal performances, there are live music venues open year-round, including the **Uptown Theater**, the **JaM Cellars Ballroom**, **Jarvis Music Conservatory**, **The Fink** and the **Napa Valley Performing Arts Center**.

June begins with plenty of excitement via **Auction Napa Valley**, the original wine charity event created by Robert and Margrit Mondavi along with other

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BottleRock

dedicated vintners in 1981. The Friday barrel auction brings the community out en masse, while the main auction on Saturday is among the poshest events of the year.

Note that this is also high season for tourism. Hotels book up quickly, and traffic and parking congestion starts to amp up. Consider starting your day early, and avoid Highway 29 between 4 p.m. and 7 p.m. when it's most busy. With the extra daylight, 8 p.m. becomes prime time for a dinner reservation.

July/August

Through summer, grapevines will show off a splendor of big green leaves hiding plump bunches of grapes that are nearing full size. Wine grape bunches are much smaller than those of table grapes, sometimes small enough to fit in your palm, even though a single bunch could have 250 berries on it.

By late July, you might notice veraison, when grapes stop growing and start to turn color from green to their purple hues for red wine grapes and golden yellow for white wine grapes. This marks the final ripening stage, and the countdown to harvest is on. You'll also notice a dramatic diurnal shift—hot days are followed by cool or cold nights. A temperature swing of 50 degrees is common. If you're dining al fresco you might need a shawl or light sweater.

Activity starts to ramp up in both the vineyards and cellars. Leaves might be pulled to give grapes exposure to sun for ripening. If it's a vigorous growing season, workers may be seen "dropping fruit" or "thinning" bunches to get better vine balance and improve the quality of the grapes. Cellar workers will be move things around to make room for impending harvest. There's often a rush of bottling, in order to empty tanks.

The **4th of July** brings fireworks, parades and family events in various towns around the valley. Held in August, the **Napa Town and Country Fair** is a quintessential small town fair with livestock, arts and crafts, carnival rides and monster truck racing.

There is still plenty of live music to enjoy, particularly in the towns of Napa and Calistoga, with concerts in local parks and **Music in the Vineyards**, a chamber music festival.

To cool off, consider some of the many local breweries and tap houses in the area, including **Fieldwork Napa**, **Armistice Brewery**, **Tannery Bend Beerworks**, **Trade Brewing, Napa Palisades Saloon**, **Napa Valley Brewing and Mad Fritz**. **Erosion Tap House**, in downtown St. Helena, offers not only beer, but homemade ice cream.

There's more to Napa Valley than just growing grapes. Summer means farmers markets are at their peak. You can rub shoulders with winemakers and local chefs if you make an early morning stroll through the weekly rotation of Napa, St. Helena, Calistoga and Yountville markets.

September/October

Harvest starts rolling after Labor Day weekend. In the mornings, keep an eye out for trucks hauling grapes from overnight or early morning picks. Traffic will be tougher and, ironically, it's also the time of year most county road improvements occur (before the rainy season starts again). Harvest traffic, construction and extra tourists means allowing extra time to reach your destinations.

There are plenty of harvest parties at wineries, with various events and dinners, grape blessings and crush parties; the **Calistoga Harvest Party** is among the largest.

September used to mean the PGA Tour's Procore Championship at the Silverado Country Club (the event is not returning for 2026). But if you're a golfer, there are a handful of additional clubs to consider: **Napa Valley Country Club**, **Vintners Golf Club**, **Eagle Vines Golf Club**, **Chardonnay Golf Club** and the public **Napa Golf Course at Kennedy Park**.

A gathering of 75 artists in more than 40 locations, the seasonal **Napa Open Studios** draws art lovers in September. Among year-round galleries, check out **Jessel**, **Aerena**, **Art Gallery Napa Valley**, **Caldwell Snyder**, **The Christopher Hill Gallery**, **Vonsaal Design**, **Meuse Gallery**, **Sofie Contemporary Arts**, **Yager Galerie** and others. **Gordon Huether** is perhaps the most prolific artist in the area and his sculptures are on display in multiple venues. There's plenty of public art to take in as well, including the **Rail Arts District** and **Yountville Art Walk**, as well as the **Napa Art Walk**.

Holidays in St Helena

November/ December

As the year winds down, vineyard leaves turn color, offering a feast for the eyes. The rains eventually return as well, offering a welcome excuse to cuddle up with some red wine.

Calistoga, **St. Helena**, **Yountville** and **Napa** will be decorated in holiday lights and offer various events, parades, visits from Santa, ice rinks and more. The **Calistoga Lighted Tractor Parade** is a local favorite.

For indoor activities, consider the local museums, including the brand new **The MAC (Museum of Arts & Culture)**, with locations in both Yountville and St. Helena. Most of the museums are small and quaint, including the **Chuck Williams Culinary Arts Museum**, the **Goodman Library**, which is home to the **Napa County Historical Society**, the **Sharpsteen Museum** and the **Robert Louis Stevenson Museum.** Not technically a museum, the castlelike **Culinary Institute of America at Greystone** is home to a collection of more than a thousand antique corkscrews. **CIA at Copia** offers cooking classes and kitchen boot camps. **Napa Cigars** and **Napa Wine and Cigars** cater to those who enjoy a quality smoke.

If pampering is part of your year-end celebrations, check out the terrific **spas** located at the top-end resorts and hotels around the valley. Some of them are exclusive to guests, but others offer day passes to access spa services. A local highlight is the geothermal mineral pools and mud baths in Calistoga. Standalone spas include **Greenhaus Day Spa** and **Napa Valley Massage & Wellness Spa**. For a relaxing meditation, consider the sound baths at **Studio Be Napa**.

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